

SEX AND THE SURVEYS

2007 sex survey

UNEQUAL PARTNERS

Involved 2,563 couples between 21 and 50 across 11 cities.

Was intended to study the status of sex and marriage

■ The use of sex toys has gone down this year with 90 per cent saying that they do not need those for sexual fulfilment compared to 81 per cent in 2007

■ Not many seem to be experimenting with various sexual positions. "Missionary position" was preferred by 72 per cent respondents in 2008 compared to 57 per cent in 2007, while "woman on top" follows second at 43 per cent as opposed to 16 per cent in 2007.

■ More people are now experimenting with kinky sex. The number of respondents who have tried anal sex has increased by 4 per cent in 2008 from 25 per cent in 2007. Bisexual sex too has shown a 5 per cent leap from 15 per cent in 2007.

2006 sex survey

MEN IN A MUDDLE

Involved 2,559 males aged between 16 and 25 across 11 cities.

To understand the unmarried Indian man's sexual preferences

■ Almost two out of five respondents in 2006 said they drew inspiration from porn while having sex. This figure has only marginally increased to six out of 10 in 2008.

■ Though Aishwarya Rai Bachchan continues to remain the most desired actor (6 per cent) in 2008, she was far more popular in 2006 when she was a single woman and had a rating three times higher than now, at 17 per cent. Moreover, Karan Kapoor (6 per cent), Kareena Kapoor (4 per cent) and Priyanka Chopra (4 per cent) have retained the sex divas of 2006. Ranusha Raut (13 per cent) and Malaika Sherawat (10 per cent)

2005 sex survey

SEX AND THE SINGLE WOMAN

Involved 2,035 single women across 11 cities between the ages of 18 and 30.

To identify an urban Indian unmarried woman's ideas of sex, fantasies and desires

■ 16 per cent women were fine with adultery in 2005 compared to only 8 per cent this year.

■ Around 84 per cent women in 2005 had never watched Internet porn. The figure is 73 per cent in this survey.

2004 sex survey

WHAT MEN WANT

Involved 2,499 married and unmarried men across 11 cities between 18 and 55 years.

To understand an average Indian male's sexual preferences

■ There is a minimal difference between men who have admitted to a homosexual experience, willingly or unwillingly, in 2008 (16 per cent) and 2004 (19 per cent).

■ The number of men having sex with prostitutes has dropped from one out of three in 2004 to one out of five in 2008.

2003 sex survey

SEX AND THE INDIAN WOMAN

Involved 2,305 women across 10 cities between 19 and 50 years.

To understand an average Indian female's sexual preferences

■ 53 per cent women in 2003 said that they preferred the missionary position compared to a much higher 76 per cent in 2005.

■ 22 per cent women admitting to having committed adultery said they had sex with their husbands' friends in 2003, the former being much higher in 2005 (45 per cent).

has a complex history. It first emerged as a term of social opprobrium and self-description. In the '70s, the gay liberationists abandoned it because of its connotations of self-loathing. In the '90s, it was revived to suggest a diverse range of non-heteronormative sexual behaviour.

Similarly, the sex workers of Durbar Mahila Samanwaya Committee prefer to call themselves sex workers in order to challenge the term 'prostitute' which, as their flyer explains, "is rarely used to refer to an occupational group who earn their livelihood through providing sexual services (but) is deployed as a descriptive term denoting a homogenised category, usually of women, who pose threats to public health, sexual morality and civic order." In order to foreground the notion of sex work as labour, they have been demanding the right to form a trade union. On the other hand, the sex workers from Veshya AIDS Muqabla Parishad (VAMP) in Sangli, Maharashtra, call themselves "women in prostitution" and see themselves engaged in an occupation (*dhanda*) which is not to be equated with a profession. The most useful part of this distinction is that it compels people to recognise that women may move in and out of prostitution, which is no different from any other occupation. Consequently, self-descriptions may vary over cultures.

Were we to regard sexualities in all their complexity, we will find that our available resources of words and understanding are limited. Therefore, it is vital that open-minded sex surveys abandon old-fashioned expressions like "adultery", "kinky sex" and "virgin" in favour of a vocabulary that is free of stigma and moralism. Sexuality studies and surveys must expand their gender categories to include 'transgenders' if they are to understand the complex range of genders and sexualities that our society inhabits. Like the characters in Mahabharata, the world cannot be divided into 'male' and 'female'. Our bodies are only one indication of our genders and sexualities. For the rest, it is important to remember scholar Carol Vance's wise observation that the "most important organ in humans is located between the ears".

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For past surveys, interactive graphics visit:
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